So great was Lala Lajpat Rai's influence in his demand for dignity from the colonial government that he inspired two generations of Indians. He was content to fight on without the assurance of a seat in government, which is not what one could say of many of the others in the Congress Party of 1905. This emboldened him to speak truth to power. The government, he declared, lacked credibility in its claim of preparing Indians for self-rule, if it was also at the same time passing repressive measures like the Rowlatt Act to stifle dissent. This reeked of humbug. In his calling out the government in this manner, which many in the Congress Party regarded to be intemperate, he was joined by Bipin Chandra Pal from Bengal and Bal Gangadhar Tilak from Maharashtra. All three chided the Congress Party for lacking any dignity.

When he was struck in the lathi charge by Superintendent Scott in Lahore, he was sixty-three years old. He recovered despite his injuries and even held some public meetings, in which he scorned the colonial government's intransigence in opposing the will of the Indian people. However, a fortnight later he fell ill again. Two days later he was dead. Whether it was death due to natural causes or whether he had a heart attack or whether he was still suffering from the long-drawn effects of the lathi blow is not known. Nor did it matter. It was enough that he had been so brutally assaulted that he died. Lajpat Rai's death at the hands of the police helped to shatter the fallacy of benign colonialism once and for all. Bhagat Singh, who saw him as his mentor, moved to take revenge.

Alongside the nationwide non-cooperation movement and Khilafat movement between 1920 and 1922, the continued existence of the revolutionary terrorist movement, from the middle of the 1920s onwards, showed that anti-colonial sentiment was widespread in India. Moreover, perhaps more alarmingly for British officials, revolutionary terrorists were drawing on global trends and were connected to international radical movements. In 1922, the Interdepartmental Committee on Eastern Unrest had already been convened in London to survey the threats the British Empire faced from Indian, Turkish and Egyptian nationalists, the pan-Islamic movement, Bolshevik activities and Indian revolutionaries in